



SHEER CLIFFS

Seabird nesting colonies attract foxes and other land predators intent on eating the eggs and chicks. This encourages the birds to choose nesting sites that the foxes cannot reach easily. Many nest on sheer cliffs with narrow ledges just wide enough for the adult birds to sit on their eggs. When the young birds are ready to leave the nest, they can simply drop off the ledge and flutter into the sea.



▲ CLIFF COLONY

Hundreds of Brünnich's guillemots nest on the cliff ledges of this Arctic shore. After breeding, they all vanish out to sea.

Seabird colonies

Ocean birds cannot lay their eggs at sea. They must return to the land to nest on solid ground. They nest as close to the water as possible, relying on the shallow coastal seas to supply them with a rich source of food to raise their young. Many of these birds form large coastal breeding colonies, especially on isolated sea stacks and islands.



▲ CONICAL EGGS

Female guillemots lay a single egg on bare cliff ledges. Like other cliff-nesters, they have conical eggs that roll in circles, so they are less likely to fall off the cliff ledges.

SAFE REFUGES

The safest nesting sites for seabirds are small islands and sea stacks. Since these are cut off from the mainland, ground predators cannot get at the nests, although they are still open to attack by predatory birds such as skuas. On many of these sites, every patch of level ground is occupied. Some island gannet colonies are so densely packed with white birds that, from a distance, they look as if they are covered with snow.

